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Luo customary law and marriage laws customs

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16. A girl may postpone marriage temporarily or have it abandoned altogether during MEKO if she claims a specific species of tree, Euphobia, called BONDO; or she may take a handful of sodom apples, which indicates that her resistance is not traditional but she, in fact, does not wish to go through with the union. She may eat earth or throw a handful at her captors. In some tribes it is sufficient for her to climb on an anthill and, facing the direction of her village, cry bitterly for her relatives. If any of these things happen, she will be allowed to return to her village. The elders will then discuss the problem and the JAGAM will try to learn of her objections. It usually happens, in cases of this type, that the girl has a secret arrangement to marry someone else who has long been her lover. Finally, the most serious action of a girl who objects is to run into a house of mourning or into a village where she knows there is another bride who has not been "LUPO". This will cancel the wedding completely.

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17. If a wedding is cancelled in this way, the girl can never be "MEKO" again, and when she does eventually marry, she must run away, POR, or must go to the village on her own, as does a bride who replaces a sister. Her children will not be "MEKO" either, and so the stigma remains for generations. Back at her village her father and mother will prepare MANYASI to cleanse the girl and the village. The boy may also be cleansed, but the KWER is thought to remain with the village and family of the girl.

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18. *Bridesmaids or Witnesses*, JONDARIA.—At the gate of the village the bride ceases her wailing and waits patiently for the young women of the village to

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take her inside. During this time the women of her own village begin to prepare food and her sisters and other age mates gather to form the JONDARIA, that is those who attend the bride and who witness the defloration. According to Paul Mboya, at least two of these should be young married women and contemporaries of the bride. When the food has been prepared, the JONDARIA take it to the village of the groom. They wait outside with the food while one of their number goes into the village to bring out the bride. There they have a meal together with the food which they brought and when it has been all consumed the bride and the JONDARIA enter the village and go to the hut which will be used for the defloration of the bride.

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Most Luo tribes state that the JONDARIA are ignored in the village and are not given food but must wait until their return the next day to their own village before they eat. This is the version which Professor Evans-Pritchard has recorded. On the other hand, some state that the JONDARIA have great licence in the village and enter the granaries and take anything edible they find which they cook and eat by themselves. The southern Luo tribes do not consider there are any avoidances at this time. Food may be brought and eaten or cooked in the village.

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19. *Defloration*, RINGRE NYAKO.—During the rest of the day is a period of flirtation and joking between the JONDARIA and the young men of the groom's village. An hour or so after dark is the time chosen for the defloration of the bride. Usually two young married girls and two young married men remain in the hut with the bride and groom. A nuptial bed is prepared by 96 the married sisters of the groom or by a senior wife, if he is married before. The bed traditionally is of an ox or bull skin. The fire is extinguished and the girls take hold of the bride and place her on the bed. If her hands or her feet touch the skin this is thought to prevent the boy from successfully performing the defloration. Then the men take hold of the groom and place him in the customary position for copulation and similarly if his hands or feet make contact with the skin of the bed, it is thought that this will "make the hymen disappear".

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